



PORTFOLIO FOUNDATION ESSAY

Mpuah Janice Wetawuki

78732029

SOAN111: Leadership Seminar I: What Makes A Good Leader?

Faculty: Mensimah Thompson Kwaffo (PhD), Belinda Gasu

Due Date: 23rd August 2026

What really is leadership?

At the close of this semester, I know that I understand that leadership is not just about being in a position where you can make the big decisions. A leader carries the responsibility to understand the people and systems around them and has to use their position to create positive change. I realized this when my team and I explored bribery as a systemic African problem. People usually think that bribery is just about **one** person giving or receiving money to get something they want, but it's actually way bigger than that. It can become a real problem when it starts getting accepted as the normal way of getting opportunities. Situations like this make people believe that hard work is not enough. My team's Creative Project explained this problem through a workplace scene where an employee was offered a position in exchange for money. The film also showed the people around the bribe and the choices they had to make. This confirmed to me that bribery isn't just an individual act but can also be an issue if it's normalized within a company.

A Leader Understands:

For a leader to even begin thinking of solving a problem, they have to understand what the root of the problem is; why it even exists in the first place. Like I started earlier, bribery is not just brought about by one person. It has to do with those who offer the bribe, those who accept it, those who get the short end of the stick and those who witness it but do not speak up about it.

Each of these stakeholders can have their reasons for their actions. Some motivated by money, others feel pressure to protect themselves and some just simply believe that's how the system works. Our film showed this through the hiring process. The hiring manager used his position to influence who received the CFO position, while Kwadwo was placed in a situation where he had to choose between an important career opportunity and his personal values. Yayra ended up being affected negatively because a decision that should have been based on good works was

unfortunately influenced by bribery. Gift also became a key stakeholder when she heard about what happened and needed to decide if she should speak up or keep quiet. Looking at all these people helped me see that bribery can't be understood by only looking at the person who takes the money. Awori's concept of values helped me understand that leadership begins with clearly knowing what we believe in and being willing to act by those beliefs (Awori, 2022b). In the film, Kwadwo knew deep down it was wrong to give money just to earn the position but the mere fact that he considered it shows that it's easier to say that you live by certain values than actually acting by those values, especially when there's something important at stake. This showed me that saying you have values is really not enough. Leaders would also need to create a space and make it known that others will be supported when they choose to do what is right. Bribery can also become systematic when people begin to expect it. If workers start to think that they need to give money or have connections to get a promotion, then hard work becomes useless. Then, workers who are honest and have integrity will start to think that they are depriving themselves and soon convert. As time goes on, bribery will start to feel normal and eventually become part of the system. In many African countries, bribery stems when companies fail to enforce their rules and regulations and with people's fear of reporting as well. Afrobarometer conducted a survey and they found that only 26% of people across 39 African countries were sure that they could report corruption without fear of retaliation (Afrobarometer, 2023). If people feel like they aren't safe when reporting these kinds of issues, they are going to remain quiet and those who practice it will continue, therefore making it normalized. With this, we can understand how bribery can become a systematic issue. Goleman (2004) talks about how important it is to be emotionally intelligent as a leader and having this quality can at least help leaders to understand

the rationale behind the actions of people and this clearly shows why addressing bribery needs both strong values, and understanding the people who commit such acts.

A Leader Strategizes:

A leader needs to come up with a plan to actually combat bribery, understanding it is not enough. With my understanding of leadership and bribery, I think the most effective way to get rid of this issue would be prevention, accountability and making employees feel safe to want to do the right thing. Like in our film, in a workplace setting, creating anti-bribery policies and having more people involved in the hiring process can help. Measures like these can reduce the power that one person has to manipulate the whole process and can even discourage them. I was able to draw a connection between this process and Awori's idea of being driven by purpose. A leader should not let personal interests trump over the interests of the business (Awori, 2022a). In this case of bribery, the main aim of the hiring process should be to choose the most qualified person, not the one who can provide the most money. Therefore, leaders need to make it a plan to enforce the company's values, not just making them known and leaving it at that. I could also apply Awori's concept of leadership as well in this case, since preventing bribery should not be up to just one person (Awori, 2022c). If major decisions are shared amongst a group of people, it makes it much harder or even almost impossible for one person to abuse their power without being apprehended. Also, we can't just leave shared leadership at that, it needs to be backed with accountability. Leaders need to make it a habit to apply necessary punishments to people who break the law regardless of position. This was shown in our film when the CEO fired both the hiring manager and Kwadwo and it lets us know that the company's values apply to EVERYONE. Unfortunately, her reaction only came after bribery had already taken place. A

better system would involve a hiring panel and clear hiring decisions so that it will be unlikely for one person to manipulate the process. This is why I think strategic leadership has to do with understanding the system and making changes so that the same problem is less likely to happen again.

A Leader Adapts:

For my group, we didn't have any huge disagreements about the concept of the project itself, but everyone had different levels of commitment to the work. Some were more laid back and didn't seem to care about the deadline and the extra work that came after filming, while others, like myself, were more focused on making sure the project was completed on time. For example, when we needed to meet to discuss our plot, some members did not attend, which meant we had to reschedule and it got frustrating because we were working toward the same deadline. This taught me that not everyone will take a task as seriously or approach it in the same way. I learnt that adapting as a leader sometimes means learning how to work with people who do things differently from me. Rather than getting mad when people don't get as involved as needed, although it was hard, I had to focus on the task at hand, do my part, and keep communicating with the group so the project keeps going. A leader still has to make sure that the group remains accountable to its goal. Cain's discussion of collaboration helped me understand that people have different ways of contributing to a group and that collaboration is not always effective simply because people are working together (Cain, 2013). This experience showed me that a successful group requires more than having different people with different strengths. It also requires constant communication, responsibility and commitment. I learnt that adaptive leadership is not

about making everyone work in the same way, but about adjusting my approach while still keeping everyone focused on what is needed to be accomplished.

Leading With Excellence:

This semester really changed how I understand leadership, and what it means to lead well. I used to think that being a good leader mainly meant serving others, making good decisions, and making sure that people felt included. I still believe these things are important but I now understand that leadership also requires self awareness, strong values, emotional intelligence and the ability to take care of oneself. I also learned that a leader needs to understand their own strengths, weaknesses, emotions and values. One of the most important lessons I have learned is the importance of emotional intelligence. According to Goleman (2004), effective leaders need more than just intelligence or capability. They also need to understand and handle their own emotions and recognize the emotions of others. I've come to realize that this is important because leadership involves working with people who may not think or act like I do. Being patient, listening and responding properly can stop small problems from becoming big ones. In working on this Creative Project, I learnt that I have to be able to work with different personalities without allowing frustration to affect my treatment of others. I have also come to learn that leadership excellence demands virtue. A leader may have the power and the ability to make decisions, but without strong values, that power can be misused. Our creative project demonstrated this through the hiring manager who used his position for his own personal gain. The CEO's decision on holding them accountable was a reminder that leadership is about having the courage to do what is right. This ties to what I've learnt about living your values. According to Awori (2022b), in difficult situations, values should guide our actions. This means that as a

leader what I say I believe in should be the same as how I act. I also just learnt that self care is part of leadership, which I never actually considered. How can I even care for others, if I'm not caring for myself? Caring for myself first will actually give me the energy to do more for others. As a future leader in Africa, I want to lead with purpose while also knowing that sustainable leadership needs this kind of balance. All of Delle's examples of African leaders showed me that leadership does in fact need action. They really need to use their skills to attend to real problems instead of just talking about change (Delle, 2020a).

To conclude, I think leading with excellence means being a leader whose words match their actions. I want to be a selfless, democratic and thoughtful leader who always listens to others and also one that has the courage to speak up when I see something wrong.

The lessons I have learnt from this leadership class throughout the whole semester have shown me that leadership is not just about a position, like I said in my introduction. It is really about how you use that position to treat people and if the decisions you make contribute to a better system for others. As I continue my leadership journey outside of this class, I hope to lead with purpose, integrity, emotional intelligence and care for both myself and others.

References.

- Afrobarometer. (2023). *Amid rising corruption, most Africans say they risk retaliation if they speak up*.
<https://www.afrobarometer.org/publication/ad743-amid-rising-corruption-most-africans-say-they-risk-retaliation-if-they-speak-up/>
- Awori, T. (2022a). Driven by purpose. In *Leadership in Africa redefined* (Chapter 2; pp. 17–23). Action Wealth Publishing.
- Awori, T. (2022b). Live your values. In *Leadership in Africa redefined* (Chapter 4; pp. 31–48). Action Wealth Publishing.
- Awori, T. (2022c). Shared Leadership. In *Leadership in Africa redefined* (Chapter 12; pp. 131–142). Action Wealth Publishing.
- Cain, S. (2013). When Collaboration Kills. In *Quiet: The Power Of Introverts In A World That Can't Stop Talking* (Chapter 3, pp. 71 - 94). Broadway
- Delle, S. (2020a). Saran Kaba Jones Waters a Nation. In *Making Futures: Young Entrepreneurs in a Dynamic Africa*. Cassava Republic.
- Goleman, D. (2004). What Makes a Leader? Harvard Business Review.
<https://hbr.org/2004/01/what-makes-a-leader>